



Blériot XI

Louis Blériot was a qualified professional engineer who, before he became interested in aviation, had made his fortune designing and producing the world’s first practical car headlight. Working with pioneers like Gabriel Voisin, Blériot produced a diverse series of aircraft and suffered a number of crashes before arriving at the Type XI, which became a huge success and set the pattern for the modern airplane after the Channel crossing of July 1909.

BLÉRIOT FIRST EXPERIMENTED with flapping-wing aircraft, none of which flew. In June 1905, he saw Gabriel Voisin’s first trials with a towed floatplane glider, leading him to commission a similar machine, which became the Blériot II. Voisin joined Blériot, building the unsuccessful models III and IV. Blériot then produced the canard (tail-first) V, which crashed, before arriving at the “tractor monoplane” configuration of the successful VII.

In its 1909 Channel crossing form, the Blériot XI combined the layout of the VII with a new engine designed by Alessandro Anzani and a propeller made by Lucien Chauvière. The engine produced low power and was prone to overheating, but was light and reliable, and Chauvière’s propeller was the most efficient in Europe at the time. After the historic flight, orders poured in and by 1914 most of the world’s military aircraft were Blériots.

SPECIFICATIONS	
Model	Blériot Type XI, 1909
Origin	France
Production	Approx. 900 (1909-1914)
Construction	Wire-braced wood frame
Maximum weight	507 lb (230 kg) plus pilot and fuel
Engine	25 hp Anzani air-cooled 3-cylinder fan
Wingspan	25 ft 7 in (7.79 m)
Length	25 ft (7.62 m)
Range	Approx. 75 miles (120 km)
Top speed	47 mph (76 km/h)

